Two years later Havell, Coomaraswamy and other like-minded individuals in England joined together to form the Indian Society, with the aim of promoting Indian art in Britain. Coomaraswamy then entered the debate with a now-famous essay, subsequently republished many times over, in *The Dance of Siva: Essays on Indian Art and Culture*, in which he proclaimed the best of Indian art to be universal. 'I do not mean to say,' he wrote,

> that the most profound interpretation of Śiva's dance was present in the minds of those who first danced in frantic, and perhaps intoxicated energy, in honour of the pre-Aryan hill-god, afterwards merged in Śiva. A great motif in religion or art, any great symbol, becomes all things to all men; age after age it yields to all men such treasures as they find in their own hearts. Whatever the origins of Śiva's dance, it became in time the clearest image of the *activity* of God which any art or religion can boast of.

In 2004 a gift from the Government of India was unveiled at CERN, the European Centre for Research in Particle Physics in Geneva, home of the proton-busting Hadron Collider. It was a 2-metre-tall statue of the Lord of the Dance, a quintessentially Tamil creation now widely regarded as the very image of Hindu India.

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It is all too easy to get bogged down in Indian history as a multiplicity of dynasties of ruling kings come and go, and to end up with a bewildering list of names that mean very little and bring no sense of perspective. Sacrifices have to be made, so the reader must forgive me if I fail to give other dynasties of the western Deccan their due; for example, the Kalachuris, whose Shaiva king Krishnaraja, a contemporary